FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

MOOD OF THE NATION

Every government has a moment when the accumulated weight of incumbency begins to show. For the Modi government, that moment appears to have arrived. The August 2026 edition of India Today's biannual Mood of the Nation survey captures the popular mood at a genuine inflexion point. It comes one month after a rare summer of public dissent, after Gen Z filled Jantar Mantar in numbers that forced the resignation of the Union minister of education and sent the government scrambling to recalibrate its entire public outreach. It comes against the backdrop of the prolonged Strait of Hormuz crisis, which created an ambient air of economic anxiety that made the protests more potent than they might otherwise have been. And it comes after what should have been a moment of pure triumph, the BJP's landslide in West Bengal in May, which gave the party control over 22 of India's 28 states and Union territories. The numbers our survey produces are instructive precisely because they do not tell a simple story.

The Modi government has forfeited some of the enormous advantage it enjoyed six months ago, slipping from 352 to 326 seats in the Lok Sabha if elections were to be held today. Still robust, but a dip nonetheless. As the main component of this, the BJP has lost the single-party majority figure of 287 it was conferred with in the January MOTN, receding to 261 seats, halfway back to the zone of ambiguity that prevailed during the Lok Sabha election of 2024, when it won only 240. The dip of 26 seats in six months is not catastrophic, but it's a signal. The direction of travel matters as much as the current position. This offers only grim solace to the Opposition. Fragmented and war-bruised across the landscape, the INDIA bloc's tally falls to 185 seats, down 47 from the 232 it won in 2024. However, the Congress as a party has directly pocketed the 26 seats the NDA/BJP has given away, swelling its tally to 106.

On personal ratings, Modi still leads the charts by far as 'best suited to be the next PM', but has dropped six points, from 54.7 per cent in January to 48.7 per cent. However, the redistribution of public affections has not flowed along a simple binary. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has risen barely by 0.5 percentage points, to inch up to 27.1 per cent. Instead, new figures have sprung up. In an eye-catching debut, Tamil Nadu chief minister Vijay nets in a good part of the floating vote at 9.2 per cent, leaving old faces like Mamata Banerjee and even Akhilesh Yadav far behind. Abhijeet Dipke of the Cockroach Janta Party makes a surprise entry, too, ahead of his one-time political hero, Arvind Kejriwal. The leadership landscape is shifting in ways that do not yet resolve into a clear alternative, but there are signs to suggest that they are actively looking.

The full import of these numbers is unmistakable.



▲ Feb. 9, 2026

We are calling it 'Warning Signals' for the NDA government. Not because its position is precarious. It is not. But because the facile dominance it has enjoyed over India's polity over 12 years is showing signs of wear in ways that would be unwise to ignore. The gap that has always existed in our surveys between Modi's personal popularity and the government's performance ratings, particularly on the economy, has widened further. The responses to our questions reveal that the Indian public is clearer now in its demand for accountability and performance. Nearly half of those polled, 47 per cent, rate the NDA government's handling of the economy as 'average', 'poor' or 'very poor'. Those who believe it is 'outstanding' or 'good', at 47.2 per cent, is the lowest since the 2023 MOTN. The overall mood leans towards pessimism, with 54.5 per cent expecting conditions to either 'deteriorate' or 'stay unchanged' in the next six months. Again echoing past MOTNs, inequality remains a key concern. A solid 43.7 per cent feel the wealthy have benefited more under Modi's rule. And 55.7 per cent believe those benefits have largely flowed to big business, a staple that's up 3 per cent since January. As many as 65 per cent report that they struggle to tide over household expenses without debt. Nearly two-thirds tick the unemployment situation as 'serious' or 'very serious'. That last figure should concentrate minds in government. Unemployment has topped the list of public concerns in every MOTN for years. It has not shifted. What has shifted is the patience of those bearing its consequences.

This edition includes a novelty: a dedicated Gen Z section. What it reveals is not the generational rupture one may assume. On core economic issues, particularly jobs and opportunity, there is near-identification between Gen Z respondents and the general public. Young India is not asking for something different from the rest of India. It is asking for the same things more urgently, more publicly and with considerably less patience.

In our cover story, we unpack every dimension of this survey, from seat projections and personal ratings to economic anxieties. The picture that emerges is of a government that retains substantial political capital since 2024 but is draining faster than it is being replenished.

But it would be foolhardy to underestimate the resilience and the smarts of Prime Minister Modi. Recently, he has responded with alacrity to the student protests. Hopefully, he will pursue with the same vigour the concerns voiced in our survey.



(Aroon Purie)